

Discipline was seen by senior Confederate commanders as a serious and persistent problem. The Southern soldier was a tough fighter but had an ingrained resistance to authority. Officers below the rank of brigadier general were elected by the men, and this no doubt led to a tolerance of minor infringements. But larger issues, such as straggling on the march and shirking combat, had to be addressed. Tough commanders imposed severe punishments, including hanging and branding, for the gravest offenses. Yet desertion rates remained high: around one in seven soldiers deserted from the Army of Northern Virginia. The causes included disillusion with the rigors of army life and concern for the welfare of their families back home, who were seen as needing the man's aid and protection in the face of increasing hardship and danger. The rarity of leave led to frequent shorter episodes of absence without permission, and troops stationed near home accepted a mild punishment for taking an unauthorized break to visit loved ones.

At its height, the Confederate army numbered some 460,000 men, and more than a million soldiers served in its ranks during the course of the war. Of these, around 250,000 were killed in combat or died from disease or hardship. Many more were wounded, only one in four coming through unscathed. Later in the war, as pessimism and casualties mounted, religious revivals swept through the Confederate camps and desertion grew to epidemic proportions. Yet thousands of hardened veterans fought on to the last, with the courage of despair and pride in their regiments.

Confederates were often viewed as unkempt and undisciplined. One of their own commanders, Brigadier General Cadmus Wilcox, even described Confederate troops as "little better than an armed mob." But the feats of hard marching, general endurance, and fighting against the odds achieved by the Confederate soldiers of the Civil War have been equaled by few other armies.